There is an old saying in the F&B trade: Summer in India belongs to the mango, not the malt. Air-conditioned dining rooms thin out, overseas visitors head home, and the spirits' calendar goes quiet. For years, the May–July stretch was where launches went to hide—sensible brands waited for the cool relief of the festive quarter before making their move.

This summer, someone forgot to follow that rule.

From the gravelled forecourt of The Imperial in New Delhi to the open skies above, Mumbai's Juhu, the 2026 season has announced itself as perhaps the most spirited in recent memory. New bars, new expressions of Scotch, freshly launched Japanese whiskies, all-new cocktail menus, and a hotel debut—all within weeks of each other, and in the heat and dust of an Indian May.









THE LEELA PALACE BENGALURU

The Azulian House—where Agave meets the botanist's garden

A Peruvian-inspired botanical dining destination with India's most ambitious agave programme yet. Bengaluru has always understood the idea of the garden city—where nature is not a backdrop but a living participant in daily life. The Leela Palace Bengaluru has leaned into that legacy with its newest dining concept, and the result is novel, to say the least.

The Azulian House is conceived as a botanist's home—a series of interconnected spaces that unfold like chapters: The Living Room, The Glasshouse, The Lab, and The Orchard. Guests move through the experience as much as they dine within it. You can eat in the open courtyard surrounded by herbs, edible plants, and fruit-bearing trees, or pull a seat directly into the kitchen and watch the craft from its very centre. The environment is intentional and unhurried; slowness, here, is not a failing but the entire philosophy.